The battery, key and the potentiometer wire connected in series form the primary circuit. The positive terminal of a primary cell of emf ε is connected to the point C and negative terminal is connected to the jockey through a galvanometer G and a high resistance HR. This forms the secondary circuit.

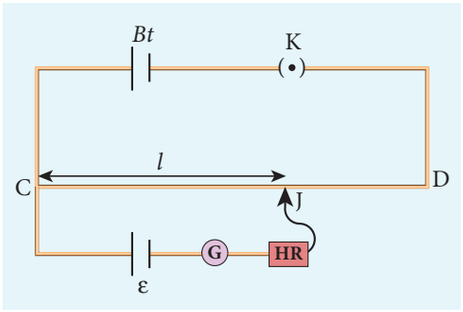


Figure 2.27 Potentiometer

Let the contact be made at any point J on the wire by jockey. If the potential difference across CJ is equal to the emf of the cell ε, then no current will flow through the galvanometer and it will show zero deflection. CJ is the balancing length *l*. The potential difference across CJ is equal to *Irl* where *I* is the current flowing through the wire and *r* is the resistance per unit length of the wire.

$$\text{Hence } \varepsilon = Irl \qquad (2.58)$$

Since *I* and *r* are constants, $\varepsilon \propto l$. The emf of the cell is directly proportional to the balancing length.

2.5.6 Comparison of emf of two cells with a potentiometer

To compare the emf of two cells, the circuit connections are made as shown in Figure 2.28. Potentiometer wire CD is connected to a battery *Bt* and a key K in series. This is the primary circuit. The end C of the wire is connected to the terminal M of a DPDT (Double Pole Double Throw) switch and the other terminal N is connected to a jockey through a galvanometer G and a high resistance HR. The cells whose emf ε_1 and ε_2 to be compared are connected to the terminals M_1,N_1 and M_2,N_2 of the DPDT switch. The positive terminals of *Bt*, ε_1 and ε_2 should be connected to the same end C.

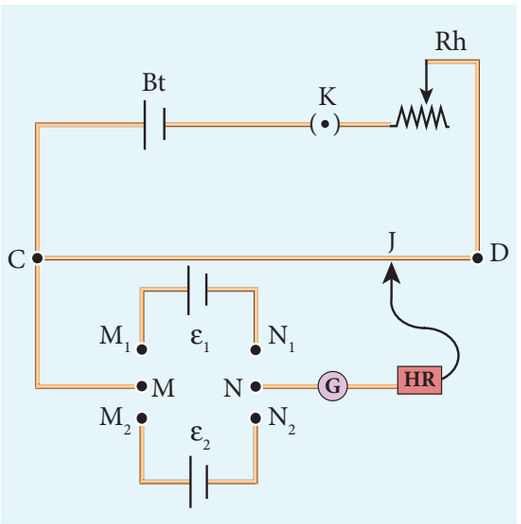


Figure 2.28 Comparison of emf of two cells

The DPDT switch is pressed towards M_1, N_1 so that cell ε_1 is included in the secondary circuit and the balancing length l_1 is found by adjusting the jockey for zero deflection. Then the second cell ε_2 is included in the circuit and the balancing length l_2 is determined. Let *r* be the resistance per unit length of the potentiometer wire and *I* be the current flowing through the wire.

$$\text{we have} \quad \varepsilon_1 = Irl_1 \qquad (2.59)$$

$$\varepsilon_2 = Irl_2 \qquad (2.60)$$

By dividing equation (2.59) by (2.60)

$$\frac{\varepsilon_1}{\varepsilon_2} = \frac{l_1}{l_2} \qquad (2.61)$$

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